efficient steel companies in the world' and a 'highly competitive modern steel producer'.

In 2008, Ratan unveiled a new plan, 'Vision 2012'. It was ambitious, expansive and transnational. It aspired to make the company the 'global industry benchmark for both value creation and corporate citizenship'. It laid out four goals which included 'value creation', improvement of 'safety', protection of the 'environment' and becoming the 'employer of choice'. It was also made clear that all expansion activities would be undertaken without Tata Steel losing 'sight of its great heritage of social and community responsibility'.

Accolades began to pour in. That year, Tata Steel won the coveted Deming Prize, awarded to organizations that 'implemented TQM [Total Quality Management] suitable for their management philosophy, scope/type/scale of business, and management environment'. But no one was prepared for what was coming.

Ratan's fairy-tale run convulsed when the external environment was suddenly scuppered by the global economic crisis of 2008. Tata Steel was more affected because of its exposure to the West. The expensive and highly leveraged Corus acquisition became a serious drain on the company. The aggressive goals were replaced by a series of strategies to contain loss. The focus shifted to 'cost reduction, process improvement and production rationalisation'.

In its pursuit to obtain more modestly priced raw material for the steel plants, Tata Steel signed an agreement with the government-owned mineral trading firm Metals and Minerals Trading Corporation (MMTC) to set up a '74:26 joint venture company for acquiring, development and operation of mines and processing of minerals and metals'. The following year, the company signed an MoU with National Mineral Development Corporation (NMDC) to explore 'possibilities of a strategic alliance'.

Tata Steel also signed an MoU for a 51:49 JV with Nippon Steel. Tata Steel's wholly owned subsidiary, Tata Steel Global Minerals Holdings Pte Ltd, established an 80:20 JV with Canadian mining company, New Millennium Capital, as well.

By 2010, the world began recovering from the economic downturn, lending hope that Corus would have enough demand for it to work at full capacity. Ratan said, 'In the coming years, Tata Steel expects to emerge as a global steel producer with a total annual output of between 40–50 million